

■ By Mihir Srivastava

For Mohammed Afzal Guru, it's the waiting that's the hardest part. So hard that the prime accused in the Parliament attack case hopes that L.K. Advani becomes the next prime minister. Not for any political reasons but to expedite the decision on his death sentence. "I really wish Advani becomes the prime minister as he is the only one who can take a decision and hang me. At least my pain and daily suffering would ease then," said Afzal, who is lodged in solitary confinement in Delhi's high-security Tihar Jail. It was exactly two years ago that the Supreme Court upheld the death sentence for Afzal and fixed October 20, 2006, as the date of his hanging. But a mercy petition, which he was reportedly opposed to, filed by his wife Tabassum and mother Ayesha Begum, saw his execution being put off two weeks before it was scheduled. The then president A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, to whom the petition was addressed, promptly referred the matter to the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) which in turn referred it to the Delhi Government for "its comments".

Two years on, in reply to a RTI query from INDIA TODAY, Rashtrapati Bhavan says it is still awaiting a reply from the MHA. Accusing the UPA Government of playing minority politics that led to the inordinate delay in Afzal's case, Advani said, "The UPA Government will be held accountable for its inaction in the Afzal Guru case... and for reducing the country's image to that of a soft



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The Noose Loosens

Even two years after the apex court upheld the death penalty for Afzal Guru, the Centre sits on his mercy petition, giving ample evidence that it places votebank politics over fighting terror

state." What the BJP leader perhaps left unsaid was the Congress party does not have the necessary will to hang a terrorist sentenced for masterminding the attack on Parliament, the symbol of Indian democracy. Indeed, if the terrorists' plans had not been foiled by the brave soldiers, six of whom sacrificed their lives, a chunk of India's political leadership cutting across party lines and ideological leanings would have been wiped out on December 13, 2001.

No party wants to be seen as being soft on terror, not even the Congress despite being known to put votebanks above tackling terrorism in its priority list. Yet, party spokesperson Manish

Tiwari found an innovative way to put the blame on the BJP in general and Advani in particular for the delay in Afzal's matter. "Advani is squarely responsible for the delay in the disposal of Afzal's clemency petition. Several such pleas were allowed to pile up during the previous government's tenure which, if cleared in normal course, wouldn't have brought us to this situation." Tiwari was referring to the long list of mercy pleas pending before the President, 15 when the NDA was in power which has now gone up to 28, without a single case being decided in the last four years. It was his contention that petitions are processed only in the order they are received by the